Does AI make Korn Ferry's work actually better?

Business Strategy | Hult International Business School | Team 2

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Executive Summary

SITUATION

Korn Ferry has 10K+ employees on GenAI tools. Early signals show value across speed, quality, and capacity. However, adoption is uneven and the top 25% of users are generating nearly all meaningful gains.

COMPLICATION

The only measurement today is self-reported time saved in timesheets which is a method that is biased, unscalable, and tells leadership nothing about whether AI is actually making the work better or worse.

QUESTION

How can Korn Ferry prove AI improves the quality of consulting output, not just the speed of producing it but in a way that's practical, scalable, and meaningful to shareholders?

OUR ANSWER

Two connected systems: an AI Output Audit Trail that scores deliverable quality before and after AI adoption, feeding a Knowledge Flywheel that makes every future interaction smarter.

The Industry Problem

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WHAT EVERYONE MEASURES

Time Saved

- Hours saved per week per employee
- Daily / weekly active user rates
- Token consumption volume
- Self-reported productivity gains
- AI tool adoption percentage

The problem: saving 2 hours producing a mediocre report is not value.

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WHAT ACTUALLY MATTERS

Quality of Work

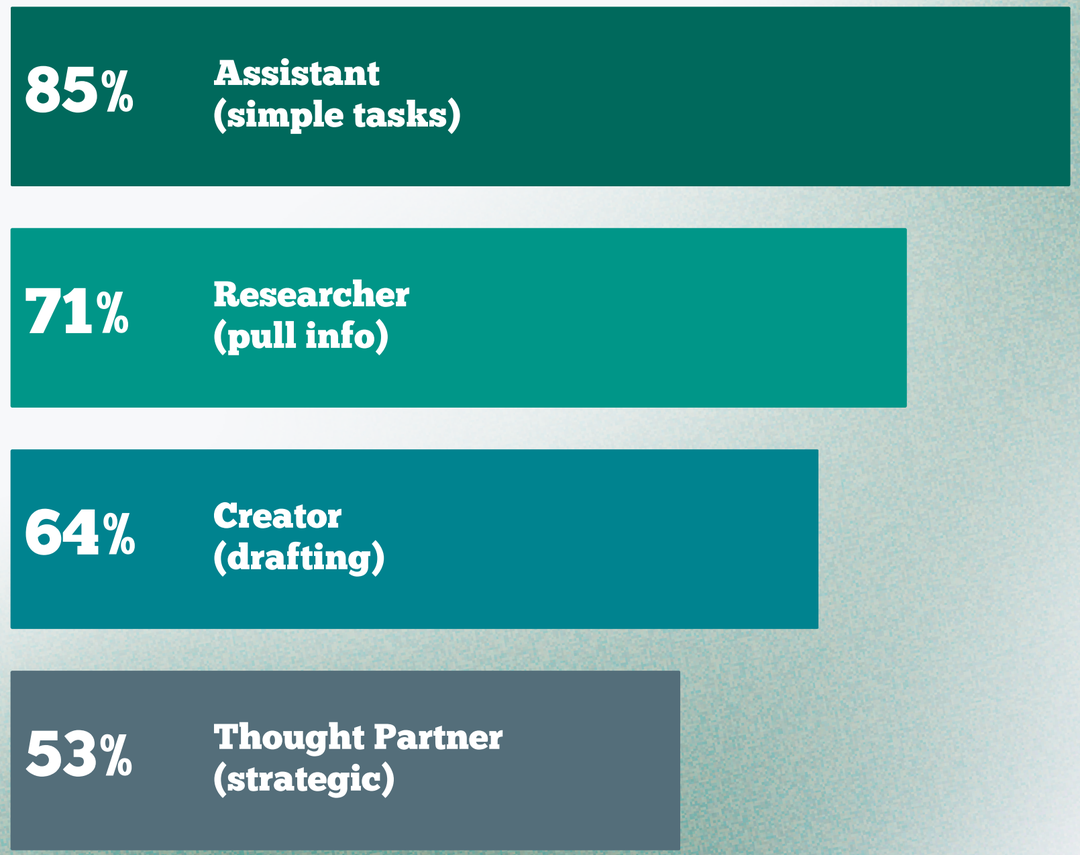
- Is the deliverable more insightful than before?
- Are client recommendations better supported?
- Does the output meet KF's quality benchmark?
- Is the firm's institutional knowledge being leveraged?
- Are outputs improving over time or are they just faster?

For a consulting firm, quality is the product. Speed is a byproduct.

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What We Heard: The Data Tells a Quality Story

How Consultants Use AI Today



← Usage drops as strategic complexity rises

The Quality Signal Hidden in the Data

Proficiency = Quality Proxy

High-proficiency users use AI in all 4 modes and report stronger impact. Low-proficiency users stick to assistant tasks.

Only 25% See Meaningful Gains

30–45% report speed/quality/capacity gains but only ~25% see large improvements. The majority is leaving quality value on the table.

No Baseline for 'Good'

KF confirmed: there is no defined quality benchmark for consulting deliverables today. That's the gap our solution fills.

Korn Ferry's AI Positioning Creates a Credibility Obligation to Have a Clear Answer

> **"Beyond time saved, how do you define and measure AI's impact on performance and outcomes? We are posing that question to the group – help us think about it. We don't have a clear answer."**

KF's 'AI Ready' Framework – What They Sell to the World

- **AI-Ready Leadership**
- **AI-Ready Workforce**
- **AI-Ready Organization**
- **AI-Ready Culture**

Why the Current Approach (Time Saved) Fails

Meaningless to Shareholders

'We saved X hours' tells shareholders nothing about whether AI is improving competitive output or client value.

Unscalable

Surveying 10,000+ employees repeatedly is resource-intensive and unreliable. KF confirmed this limitation directly.

Biased

Self-report creates positivity bias. Employees over-report time saved, especially for internal surveys.

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Stop asking employees how AI helped them. Let the work answer the question.

SYSTEM 1

AI Output Audit Trail

Score the quality of consulting deliverables before and after AI adoption by using the work itself, not surveys.



Feedback Loop

SYSTEM 2

Knowledge Flywheel

Every high-quality AI output feeds a KF-specific intelligence layer, making every future consultant smarter from day one.

System 1: The AI Output Audit Trail

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1 Establish Quality Baselines

Define a rubric for recurring deliverable types. Existing high-rated outputs become the benchmark on the following completeness, insight depth, client relevance, accuracy, turnaround.

2 Tag AI-Assisted Outputs

A lightweight binary flag in KF's existing project tools marks whether AI was used. No behavioral tracking. No prompt capture. Just: AI-assisted? Yes / No.

3 Score Against the Rubric

Manager scores each deliverable using the same rubric. Builds a growing dataset: AI-assisted outputs vs. baseline by deliverable type, team, practice area, and consultant proficiency level.

4 The Quality Dashboard

Quality score trends over time, broken down by AI adoption rate. KF can now answer: does AI-assisted work score higher? Where does it help most and where does it hurt?

Before the Audit Trail

- I think AI helped on that project.
- We saved maybe 2 hours last week.
- No idea if the output was better or worse.
- Can't tell consultants where AI adds the most value.
- Nothing to show shareholders about quality.

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After the Audit Trail

- Quality gains concentrated in research + synthesis tasks.
- Assessment reports: AI helps junior consultants reach senior-level quality.
- Identified 3 deliverable types where AI reduces quality — now flagged.
- Shareholder narrative: AI improves output quality in 6 of 8 deliverable types.

System 2: The Knowledge Flywheel

The Problem Today:

Every KF consultant using AI starts from zero – ignoring decades of proprietary frameworks, validated assessments, leadership models, and high-quality past deliverables. Generic AI tools have no access to what makes Korn Ferry, Korn Ferry.

1 Build the KF Knowledge Layer

Feed KF's proprietary assets into a structured RAG layer: Success Profiles, competency models, assessment frameworks, anonymized high-scoring past deliverables. `

2 The Flywheel Mechanism

When the Audit Trail identifies a high-scoring AI-assisted output, that work is reviewed and optionally added to the knowledge base.

3 Compounding Returns Over Time

The metric is no longer hours saved. It's time-to-insight compression: how much faster does the firm reach a high-quality output on a given deliverable type, quarter over quarter?

4 The Democratization Effect

A junior consultant in Singapore instantly accesses methodology a senior partner in New York used on a similar engagement last year. AI becomes the great equalizer across KF's global footprint.

How the Two Systems Connect: The Feedback Loop

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Consultant Prompts AI
Uses KF Knowledge Layer

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Output Produced
Tagged: AI-assisted

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Audit Trail Scores Quality
vs. baseline rubric

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High Score → Knowledge Base
Best work feeds Flywheel

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Knowledge Layer Improves
Next interaction starts smarter

← Every cycle raises the quality floor

Quality Compounds

The firm gets measurably better at AI-assisted work over time – with data to prove it.

Knowledge Is Retained

When a senior consultant leaves, their best methodologies stay in the system forever.

New Hires Start Smarter

Junior consultants access the firm's best work on day one – flattening the experience curve.

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Reality Check: This Is Feasible with What KF Already Has

Audit Trail

Component	What's Required	Feasibility
Quality rubric	Built from existing high-rated deliverables and no new data collection	✓ Ready now
AI-assist flag	Binary tag in existing project tools (Teams, SharePoint, internal PM)	✓ Ready now
Manager scoring	Extends existing review processes and adds ~5 min per deliverable	◑ Small lift
Quality dashboard	Built on adoption data KF already pulls from provider dashboards	◑ Small lift

Knowledge Flywheel

Component	What's Required	Feasibility
KF Knowledge Layer	RAG layer on existing AI tools (Copilot/Claude) pointing at KF's asset library	◑ Medium build
Content curation	Opt-in process: managers nominate high-scoring outputs for the knowledge base	✓ Process only
PII sanitization	Standard anonymization of client data which KF already does this for case studies	✓ Already done
Metric: time-to-insight	Track turnaround on defined deliverable types, quarter over quarter	✓ Ready now

The Strategic Upside: Build It Once, Sell It Forever

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**KF doesn't just fix an internal measurement problem.
They build the proof-of-concept for a new client offering.**

Credibility with Clients

Every KF client engagement on AI transformation can now be backed by: 'Here's how we measured AI quality impact on our own consulting work. Here's the data. We can build the same for you.'

New Revenue Stream

The Audit Trail + Flywheel system becomes an efficient offering under the 'AI Ready' framework & sold to enterprise clients who face the same measurement problem KF faces today.

Proprietary Competitive Moat

As the Knowledge Flywheel grows, KF's AI becomes more capable than any generic model. No competitor can replicate decades of validated KF-specific consulting intelligence.

Talent Magnet

Consultants who join KF get access to an AI that already knows the firm's best work. That's a powerful recruiting and retention differentiator as the war for AI-fluent talent intensifies.

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Implementation Roadmap: Three Phases

PHASE 1 · 0-3 Months
Build the Baseline

- Define quality rubric for 3–5 recurring deliverable types
- Score existing high-rated outputs to set the benchmark
- Add AI-assist binary tag to project management tools
- Pull token consumption + adoption dashboards as context data

PHASE 2 · 3-6 Months
Activate the Flywheel

- Begin scoring AI-assisted vs. non-assisted deliverables
- Identify first cohort of high-scoring outputs for knowledge base
- Build RAG layer on top of Copilot/Claude pointing at KF's asset library
- Track time-to-insight on pilot deliverable types

PHASE 3 · 6-12 Months
Scale & Productize

- Expand rubric scoring firm-wide across all practice areas
- Publish quarterly quality dashboard to leadership + shareholders
- Package the system as a client-facing offering under 'AI Ready'
- Measure: quality score YoY, time-to-insight compression, proficiency distribution

Success metrics: Quality score improvement YoY · Time-to-insight compression · Knowledge base growth rate · Proficiency distribution shift

They measure time saved.

We measure quality gained.

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- **Everyone in the industry measures time. That's a speed metric for a commodity business. Consulting is not a commodity business.**
- **The Audit Trail makes the deliverable the instrument with no surveys, no bias, no friction. Just: did the work get better?**
- **The Flywheel turns every high-quality output into institutional knowledge while compounding the quality advantage quarter over quarter.**
- **KF doesn't just solve its own measurement problem. It builds the proof-of-concept for a new client offering that no competitor has.**

Thank you – Questions?